

In this fourth installment of Digit's 'Icons of Trust' survey, we've listened to some of the lakhs of Digit readers out there, heard their opinions, tabulated everything, and come to conclusions. The results are out, and it's time to hear what India's largest and most influential technology community has to say to all the brands out there

THE T FACTOR

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The Icons of Trust survey we do is much more than a simple study of market perceptions. Whether it's a large screen TV for the family, or a business phone for your boss, you – the average Digit reader – are generally well informed, and take the trouble to know about brands, products and technology in general. With the recent shift of Digit readers from consumers to prosumers, your impact on the Indian technology market is a given, which is what makes your opinions more important than anything else.

This survey is of equal interest to readers and brands alike, because as readers, this is a sort of validation or reference to what your peers think and feel, and more importantly, have experienced when buying technology. This is what will help you buy smarter and ensure that money you (or your family and friends) spend, is spent well. For brands, the results have obvious implications – listen to your customers, give them what they need and in return, sell more as a result. It's all about making sure your voice reaches the ears of those who are making products to sell to you, and we're just playing catalyst here.

This year we covered the hottest selling categories in technology: cellphones, laptops, HDTVs, PMPs, desktop PCs, digital cameras, PC monitors, external storage and MFDs/printers. The difference from last year's survey is that we combined MFDs and Printers into a single category, and more importantly, included HDTVs.

HOW WE TRUSTED

How is trust calculated?

All respondents are asked to complete a rather long and comprehensive questionnaire, which aims at arriving at scores for five parameters: Awareness, Satisfaction, Cost of Ownership, Credibility and Loyalty. These five factors are what determine how much the respondents "trust" a brand.

Awareness: We're not likely to buy or recommend something we've never heard of before. To get figures for awareness, we asked the respondents some questions to see how many knew of the brands in this segment. This is again sub-divided into first, unaided recall, such as, "Which is the first brand that comes to mind"; later, we provided people with a list of the brands, and asked them which they were aware of to measure aided recall.

Credibility: Questions were asked to gauge what respondents felt about the quality, durability, technological advancement, design, innovativeness, etc., of each brand.

Satisfaction: As owners of a brand's products, how satisfied you are with their products is one of the key factors that influence how much you trust the brand. In this regard, we questioned the respondents as to how satisfied they were after purchasing a product, how easily available was it, how hard was it to find

information about it, how well-informed were the sales people about the product, how easy was it to get after-sales support... you get the idea.

Loyalty: A lot goes into making people stay loyal to a brand. Although our interactions with fanboys online is not always a good experience, you have to give credit to brands for being able to incite passion in their buyers. To ascertain the loyalty that respondents held for brands, we asked them a series of questions such as "Would you buy another cell phone of the same brand again", and whether, based on their experiences, they would buy a product in a different category from the same brand. We also gauged how eager the respondents were to recommend products from this brand to friends and relatives, and whether the respondent generally spoke positively or negatively about the brand.

Total cost of ownership: Not all products can be bought once, used forever. There's expenditure even after the purchase for servicing and repair, which may or may not fall under the warranty period, thus affecting your total cost of ownership. To ascertain this, we asked the respondents a series of questions to determine how much they had spent on a brand after purchase. This factors in the warranty, repair costs, upgradation (if any), etc. We also sought the respondents' opinions about which brands they felt were cheaper to own...

